

Q.3) (a) Discuss Victor Turner's concept of liminality and communitas in the context of religious rituals. (20 marks)

• Victor Turner was an anthropologist from symbolic school of Anthropology.

• Works - "The Forest of Symbols"
• Schism and Continuity in an African Society.

• Basic Premise and Influence

- ① He was influenced by Émile Durkheim's idea of social solidarity
- ② social solidarity is a function of symbols which connect people.
- ③ Turner said symbols are primary instruments in achieving social solidarity.
- ④ Rituals are symbols which play central role in maintaining social order

Concept of liminality

① Every ritual is aided by rites of passage with 3 primary stages:

Separation $\rightarrow$ Liminality $\rightarrow$ Re-Integration.

Liminality is characterized as:

- anti-structure phase.
- loss of previous status
- Haven't achieved new status
- Symbolized by ambiguity.

(eg.) Upanayan ceremony is rite of passage and liminal phase between childhood and joining school of learning.

Concept of communitas

- ① Communitas is formed by all those who undergo ~~social~~ liminal phase together.
- ② It results in formation of intense solidarity.
- ③ Communitas can be of 3 types
 - ① Spontaneous communitas: Due to sudden change, those undergoing have solidarity

② Ideological communities: Amongst those who have similar beliefs, values etc.

③ Normative communities: Rules, norms bound the community. This is point where schism begins and new liminal phase happens to ensure social solidarity. Schism happens as norms end up stagnating the structure.

④ Study of Ndembu ~~tree~~ ^{society} and Puberty rituals

- During puberty rituals, girls are wound up blanket and put under Mudyi tree
- Mudyi tree symbolizes a mother through its white latex secretion similar to mother's milk
- It shows liminality as it signifies change in role for girls.
 - They are no more girls during the ritual

→ However, they haven't achieved status of woman.

→ Liminality as child is supposed to swallow ~~instruction~~ from mother and learn rights, duties of woman first.

③ communitas is formed amongst girls who undergo together.
↳ similar time of beginning of menarche.

↳ support for ~~man~~ preparing for marriage and motherhood.

Criticism of liminality and communitas

① Overly positive interpretation by Turner
(eg. liminal phase of economic struggles
[Nazism] emerged as communitas (Handelman))

② Ignores power dynamics at play during rituals.

(eg. Erode, Sallnow ⇒ Christian pilgrimages aren't liminal in shedding past social status
↳ rather reinforces social hierarchy as difference in pilgrimage method

Turner enriched our understanding of society in 1156 his studies